changed after a Tangkhul man was assaulted in Ukhrul on February 7, and suspected Kuki militants and Naga village volunteers engaged in a gunfight. Two Kukis, one Naga lay dead. The conflict map had widened—and darkened.

Khemchand has tried to broker peace—visiting Ukhrul villages, activating the NDA's multi-ethnic MLA contingent, calling civil society for talks. "All issues can be resolved via dialogue," he told a gathering at Wangjing-Tentha on April 22. But his words aren't getting to the last mile: protesters had barricaded his path, forcing him to use a chopper.

Not all the action was in his lane. Around 8,500 CRPF men were pulled for West Bengal election duty at the worst time possible; Manipur detonated within that security void. On April 27, the mood must have been grim as Union home secretary Govind Mohan reviewed the situation with central and Northeast top brass. The plan now: mine-protected vehicles and CRPF's CoBRA battalions, once Bengal is done.

Takeaways

- **Imphal valley on fire after rocket attack on village**
- **CM scrambles for peace, as 'war' reaches Naga hills**

But the barbed ethnic lines are for him to pacify. Meiteis frame the Tronglaobi attack as war. They want the ceasefire with 25 Kuki-Zo militias junked, and an Assam-style NRC aimed at "illegal Chin-Kukis" from Myanmar. Kukis, too, call the April 24 assaults on their villages "a clear declaration of war". Neither side trusts the uniform. The other day, an Assam Rifles convoy was mobbed. It will take more than strategic procrastination. ■

▶ ODISHA

A Matter of SIRVival

Odisha heats up before the main voter revision process as 980,000 names get erased in the prelims

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT LOOKS LIKE AN ENCORE OF BENGAL as the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), like a spreading cyclone, makes landfall in neighbouring Odisha—wreaking pretty much the same effect. Nearly 980,000 names stand erased in the first layer of clean-up—a sieve accounting for deaths, relocation and the like. An annual exercise in non-SIR times, officials say this layer typically sees a much slimmer deletion rate. This year's figure, arrived at after a contentious field mapping across January-March, has raised alarm bells within the Opposition—especially since the 'special intensive' part is yet to come.

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) was quick to sound the warning, with senior leaders Debi Prasad Mishra, Prasanna Acharya and Bijay Nayak calling a presser to question the scale of deletions. The annual January revision usually accounts for about 700,000 deletions, they say, adding: "That 980,000 lakh voters have been removed within just one year and four months, despite being on the rolls earlier, raises significant concerns."

Writing to chief electoral officer (CEO) R.S. Gopalan, the BJD warned of "large-scale disenfranchisement", citing the nearly 200,000 Form-7 objections as evidence of widespread unease. Especially vulnerable, the party argued, are migrant workers—excluding them merely due to their absence during verification strips them of their "fundamental rights", it said. State Congress chief Bhakta Charan Das, too, demanded strict scrutiny, saying "980,000 is quite a large number".

Takeaways

- **The first-layer deletions raise alarm, being 40% higher than usual annual clean-up**
- **Disenfrachisement, says BJD, citing 200,000 Form-7 objections; EC orders relook**



COUNTING CORPS EC officials in Ganjam district, Odisha, Apr. 26

ADMISSION OF FAULT?

Faced with mounting criticism, CEO Gopalan moved to tighten oversight. Authorities acknowledge lapses. Many 'deleted' voters still live in their constituencies; in others, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) allegedly skipped proper field verification. An implicit mea culpa came as the CEO directed electoral registration officers to ensure "at least 50 per cent" of the Form-7 objections are physically verified.

All wrongfully deleted voters have been promised restoration; complaints via helplines, email and grievance portals are now under review. Yet, the politics is heating up, with minister Suresh Pujari dropping broad hints of "infiltrators in Odisha". ■